



BROWN HAWK



BROWN WOOD



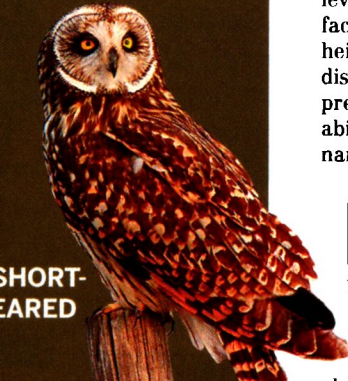
MOTTLED WOOD



EURASIAN EAGLE



ORIENTAL SCOPS



SHORT-EARED

occurrence reports and a heap of misconceptions," says E.A. Jayson, a senior scientist with KRFI's Wildlife Biology Division. Since only diurnal birds of prey had been researched earlier, the objective of the study was to make an inventory of forest owls in the area, find out factors that influence their distribution and characterise microhabitat use. Intensive surveys were carried out at 276 places across two states. "The information available so far was only based on their calls. Being nocturnal, they depend on calls for communication," says S. Babu, a senior research fellow and member in the team which won an award at the State Science Congress for this study. The study was always conducted only after nightfall due to the bird's nocturnal character.

And their unforgettable experience from the nocturnal owl trail? "None of us quiet like the bird's infamous shrill call at night but these nocturnal birds serve humans by preying on rodents and other insects which damage crops," says M. Sivaram, another member of the team.

Owl species are generally divided into larger and lesser varieties, based on size. India's lesser owls range from 15 to 30 cm in length and weigh up to 2 kg; larger owls can be up to 50 cm long and weigh up to 3.5 kg. The world's largest owl is the Eurasian Eagle Owl of Europe and Asia which can weigh up to 5 kg.

While the study reveals that the distribution of lesser owls is abundant in protected areas, larger owls like the Great Indian Horned Owl and

Forest Eagle Owl occur significantly in unprotected areas. The highest encounter rate of owls in unprotected areas was recorded from the Nelliampathy-Parambikulam Vazhachal-Anamalai hill complex. In protected areas, most species were found in the Indira Gandhi Wildlife Sanctuary and National Park of Tamil Nadu while lesser-found owls like Barred Jungle Owlet, Collared Scops, Oriental Scops and Brown Hawk Owl were encountered in protected areas.

Distribution of birds was characterised by using vegetation types, topographic variables, disturbance levels and status of protection. While factors like tree height, girth, canopy height and type of forest regulated the distribution of many lesser owls, the presence of water bodies and availability of prey were crucial determinants for larger owls.

Most owl species of the Western Ghats do not belong to the endangered category thanks to their large distribution. A few like the Forest Owl seen in central India are considered 'critically endangered and rare' and are placed in the Red Data List by the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) while the Rock Eagle Owl and Brown Fish Owl have been placed in the vulnerable category. "Though not endangered, our study indicates the need for special protection measures and appropriate conservation strategies to protect the species in the Western Ghats," says Jayson. Granite mining in the Western Ghats of Tamil Nadu poses a threat, as do deforestation and plantations. However, the biggest threat to the bird comes from practitioners of black magic and quacks. Unscrupulous poachers and middle-men are reported to pass off common barn owls as rare and more expensive forest species like the Great Indian Horned Owl by staining their eyes red and selling them to businessmen who keep them for good fortune. In some parts, owls are tortured to find treasure. The real treasure, however, is the bird itself. And it's in trouble. ■